FYE Research & Engagement
Project Proposal

Project Title Skill Development & Career Readiness for FYE Student Employees

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Supervisor: Dani Fernandez, FYE Program Coordinator
Project Duration: Aug 24, 2026 to Dec 11, 2026

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1 Project Purpose and Objectives

Purpose: First-Year Experience (FYE) will assess the skill development and career readiness practices currently built into the program for student employees—including weekly competency reflection, assessment, and feedback; guided professional goal-setting; and interview support. Data will be collected from new FYE student employees, returning employees, and past employees who have started post-graduate careers. Findings will be used to strengthen the program's developmental impact on student employees.

Objectives: By the end of this project, the student will be able to:

- Document FYE's existing weekly competency cycle (Practice Plan, Self-Report, supervisor/lead feedback) and related check-in / evaluation touchpoints.
- Align FYE competencies with recognized career-readiness frameworks (e.g., NACE Career Readiness Competencies; employer skill priorities from NACE Job Outlook and WEF Future of Jobs sources).
- Design and/or refine assessment instruments for weekly reflection quality, mid- and end-of-semester evaluation, goal-setting, and interview readiness *[TBD: Work Package fields / competency rubric]*.
- Collect and analyze multi-cohort evidence (new, returning, and alumni/post-graduate employees) using mixed methods *[TBD: survey items, interview protocol, sample size]*.
- Produce actionable recommendations for FYE to improve competency reflection, feedback, goal-setting, and interview support practices.

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2 Project Scope

In Scope:

- Review of local practice documents (FYE role expectations/Work Package cycle; campus student employment evaluation templates; Career Center handbook resources).
- Framework alignment using NACE career readiness competencies / Job Outlook employer attributes and WEF future-skills outlook.

- Assessment of weekly competency reflection, written feedback, guided goal-setting, and interview-support activities for FYE student employees.
- Multi-cohort inquiry: new FYE student employees, returning employees, and past employees in early post-graduate careers *[TBD: sampling / recruitment]*.
- Synthesis of findings into recommendations for program improvement (instruments, training, feedback quality, interview prep).

Out of Scope:

- Redesign of FYE's full organizational structure, payroll, or hiring policy beyond recommendations related to developmental practices.
- Clinical/psychological assessment of students or evaluation of academic course grades outside UNIV 389 / employment-linked reflection artifacts.
- Building production software systems or large-scale predictive hiring models.
- Generalizable claims beyond FYE / Chico State student-employee context without appropriate caveats.
- Experimental interventions that cannot be approved and completed within the semester timeline (deferred to recommendations / future work as needed).

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3 Methodology Overview

This project uses a **practice-based, mixed-methods assessment** approach rather than a purely predictive modeling pipeline.

1. **Document & process mapping.** Inventory FYE's built-in developmental practices (weekly Practice Plan / Self-Report / feedback; 1:1s; mid-semester evaluation; rehire/exit interview; UNIV 389 linkage) and compare with campus Career Center employment evaluation norms.
2. **Framework crosswalk.** Map FYE competencies (once confirmed) to NACE Career Readiness Competencies and selected WEF/NACE employer-valued skills (e.g., communication, teamwork, professionalism, critical thinking, leadership, adaptability, lifelong learning; emerging AI literacy as optional).
3. **Instrument development / adaptation.** Adapt existing evaluation structures (e.g., 1–4 supervisor rubrics and reflective prompts) and Career Handbook tools (skill statements; STAR interviewing) into study instruments for reflection quality, goal-setting, and interview readiness. *[TBD: instrument packet pending Work Package templates]*
4. **Data collection (planned).**
    - Artifact review of de-identified weekly competency entries and feedback samples *[TBD: access / consent]*

- Survey(s) for new and returning employees *[TBD: draft items]*
- Alumni / post-graduate retrospective survey or short interviews on perceived career readiness and use of FYE experiences in interviews *[TBD: recruitment]*

5. **Analysis.** Descriptive quantitative summaries (participation/fidelity, self/supervisor ratings where available) plus qualitative coding of reflection/feedback themes and interview-support usefulness. Triangulate across cohorts where possible.
6. **Reporting.** Translate findings into a written report, presentation, and stakeholder recommendations for FYE program improvement.

Tools may include (but are not limited to):

- Spreadsheet / form tools for rubrics and survey drafts (e.g., Excel, Google Forms, or Qualtrics if available)
- Document analysis of FYE Work Package artifacts and evaluation templates
- Qualitative coding (manual or tool-assisted spreadsheet codebook)
- Descriptive statistics and simple visualizations (Excel, R, or Python)
- Reference frameworks: NACE Job Outlook 2026 Spring Update; WEF Future of Jobs Report 2025; Chico State Career Handbook (Vol. 25)
- Interview-support materials based on STAR / behavioral interviewing guidance

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4 Timeline and Benchmarks

Phase	**Timeframe**	**Key Benchmarks**
Project Planning & Problem Definition	Weeks 1–2	Approved problem statement and project plan; initial document inventory
Practice Mapping & Framework Review	Weeks 3–4	Process map of weekly competency cycle; draft NACE/WEF crosswalk
Instrument Design & Data Access Prep	Weeks 5–6	Draft survey/interview/rubric packet; data-access / consent checklist (*[TBD]*)
Data Collection & Organization	Weeks 7–10	Cohort responses and/or artifact sample collected; codebook started (*[TBD: depends on access]*)
Analysis & Interpretation	Weeks 11–12	Descriptive results + thematic findings; gap analysis vs. employer frameworks
Reporting & Visualization	Weeks 13–14	Draft report, figures/tables, and recommendations brief
Final Delivery & Presentation	Weeks 15–16	Final report, presentation, and organized project materials submission

5 Deliverables

Required Deliverables:

1. **Project Proposal** (this document)
2. **Documented Practice Map & Competency Crosswalk**
    - FYE weekly reflection / feedback / goal-setting / interview-support process map
    - Alignment matrix to NACE / selected WEF–employer skill priorities
3. **Assessment Packet (draft-to-final)**
    - Adapted evaluation/reflection instruments
    - Goal-setting and interview-support prompts/checklists
    - Notes on incomplete items / assumptions where FYE templates are still pending
4. **Dataset(s)** / **Evidence Binder** (*[TBD: scope depends on access]*)
    - Cleaned, documented survey/artifact extracts (de-identified)
    - Codebook and data dictionary
5. **Analysis Workbook** / **Scripts**
    - Well-documented spreadsheets, scripts, or notebooks
    - Reproducible summary tables/figures where data permit
6. **Final Written Report** (15–25 pages, or per program guidelines)
    - Executive summary
    - Methodology
    - Findings and insights
    - Limitations and future work
7. **Final Presentation**
    - 10–15 slide professional presentation summarizing the project

Optional Deliverables (if applicable):

- Stakeholder-facing recommendations brief for FYE leadership
- Interview-support workshop outline for student employees / Training Leads
- Interactive summary dashboard (only if dataset size warrants)
- Technical appendix (instruments, codebook, additional tables)

6 Success Criteria

The project will be considered successful if:

- The assessment approach is appropriate for evaluating FYE's developmental employment practices and is methodologically sound given available data.
- FYE practices are clearly documented and meaningfully aligned to external career-readiness / employer skill frameworks.
- Results (even if partial) are clearly explained, evidence-supported, and honest about limitations / incomplete elements.
- Deliverables meet academic and professional standards expected by FYE Research & Engagement.
- Recommendations are actionable for improving weekly competency reflection, feedback, goal-setting, and/or interview support.
- The student demonstrates independent problem-solving, critical thinking, and responsible handling of student-employee information.

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7 Risks and Mitigation Strategies

Risk	**Mitigation**
Limited access to Work Package artifacts, competency rubrics, or historical evaluations	Prioritize process documentation + framework crosswalk first; use campus evaluation templates as interim instrument models; escalate data needs early with supervisor
Low survey / alumni response rates	Keep instruments short; use FYE communication channels; treat qualitative interviews/artifact review as contingency evidence
Scope creep (too many cohorts, instruments, or interventions)	Advisor check-ins and milestone approvals; freeze MVP instrument set by Weeks 5–6
Time constraints within the semester	Clear benchmarks and prioritized tasks; mark incomplete areas explicitly; deliver partial analysis with strong recommendations if data arrive late
Privacy / FERPA / consent constraints	De-identify data; collect only needed fields; follow supervisor guidance and campus policy before any primary data collection

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8 Approval

Student Signature: _____ **Date:** _____

Supervisor Signature: _____ **Date:** _____

Draft proposal aligned to the FYE Research & Engagement Project Proposal template. Items marked [TBD] are intentionally incomplete pending further definition with the supervisor (instruments, sampling, data access, and final analytical depth).